



FESTIVAL HIGHLIGHTS Left, the festival pays tribute to Nana Patekar with a screening of *Yatra*; Raghubir Yadav will perform in the play *Piano*

THEATRE ▼

IT'S PLAY TIME

Hyderabad's Qadir Ali Baig Theatre Festival brings nine days of compelling performances, celebrated actors and tributes to theatre legends

The Qadir Ali Baig Theatre Festival returns to Hyderabad from November 12 to 20 for its 21st edition, bringing together leading figures from Indian theatre and cinema for performances, masterclasses and workshops across the city's historic venues. Curated by Padma Shri recipient Mohammad Ali Baig, the festival honours his father, the late theatre doyen Qadir Ali Baig, while celebrating the continuing relevance of live performance.

"Baba was truly ahead of his times," says Mohammad Ali. "His plays in such a short span of time set a template for the rest of the country to follow. I based my theatre on the same template of that blend of art and commerce, high aesthetics with popular appeal." What began as a son's tribute has grown into an annual meeting point for leading theatre practitioners.

This year's programme features Rakesh Bedi performing Vijay Tendulkar's *Massage*, while Raghubir Yadav appears in *Piano*, an adaptation of Ferenc Karinthy's *Steinway Grand*. The festival honours Nana Patekar and Smita Patil through Goutam Ghose's *Yatra* (2006) and Jabbar Patel's acclaimed Marathi film *Jait Re Jait* (1977), respectively. Masterclasses by Patel and Yadav, alongside workshops on lighting design and theatre for children, complete the programme.

Mohammad Ali attributes the festival's international outlook to his upbringing in a theatre family and early exposure to overseas productions. "Tradition and the contemporary, global flavour yet deep-rooted in our own culture—this ethos forms the basic premise of the Qadir Ali Baig Theatre Foundation and the festival," he explains, emphasising dignity, prestige and pride in theatrical practice.

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Performances are often followed by traditional 'Hyderabadi Chowki' dinners at the Baig family's haveli, extending the festival's celebration of theatre into the realms of cuisine and heritage.

Asked about theatre's future amid digital entertainment, Mohammad Ali remains confident. "Theatre has survived it all: films, television, YouTube, OTT and now various other digital formats. Audiences who want the experience of live theatre will continue to come and watch it, as they have all these years." ■

—Nikhil Sardana

The theatre festival will be held in Hyderabad from ***Nov. 12-20***

THE LISTI

Upcoming musical perfor

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Multicity

Diljit Dosanjh: Aura India Tour

Following international performances and a headline show at London's Wembley Stadium, Diljit Dosanjh brings his Aura World Tour back to India. Blending his biggest hits with high-energy bhangra and large-scale production, the tour celebrates the Punjabi superstar's journey from Punjab to the global stage. Audiences can expect an exuberant live experience, combining contemporary pop spectacle with the sounds and cultural identity that define his music. Having kicked off in Delhi on Oct. 30, the tour now heads to Indore, Ahmedabad, Mumbai, Bengaluru, Lucknow, Chandigarh and Kolkata, taking the celebration to fans across the country.



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